TWEET WARS



"Listen Kejriwal, when humankind was reeling under the impact of Covid, you forced workers from UP to leave Delhi... Should we call you inhumanitarian or..."

YOGI ADITYANATH
The UP CM, in response to his Delhi counterpart calling the PM's statement on migrant workers an 'outright lie'



"Listen Yogi, you should leave this alone. Dead bodies were floating in the river and you were spending crores to give ads...in the 'Time' magazine. I have not seen a more merciless and cruel ruler than you"

ARVIND KEJRIWAL
The Delhi CM's riposte to Yogi Adityanath's accusation

WINDOW SEAT
KHATIMA, UTTARAKAHND

Khatima Chronicles

A short distance from India's border with Nepal, there is nothing to recommend Khatima except for its bustle as a minor business hub. However, this small town in the terai is having a brief moment in the sun this assembly election, as Uttarakhand's young chief minister, the 46-year-old Pushkar Singh Dhami, prepares for a third win from this constituency.

Pitted against him are old, familiar foes: Bhuwan Chandra Kapri of Congress—whom he scraped past in 2017 with a slender margin of 2,709 votes—and the Bahujan Samaj Party's Ramesh Rana. The Congress's chief ministerial hopeful Harish Singh Rawat is in the vicinity too, contesting from the neighbouring Lalkuan constituency.

Part of the Nainital-Udham Singh Nagar Lok Sabha constituency, Khatima is slung below the foothills of the Kumaon division, which contributes 29 members to the 70-member legislative assembly. Elections here are on February 14, and Dhami is relying on the BJP slogan—*'Abki baar, 60 paar'*—to power both his campaign and his self-belief.

Not that Dhami needs any confidence-booster. His party vested faith in him when they brought the young Kumaoni to replace two chief ministers in quick succession. What could play spoiler is Khatima's growing complaints about its crumbling education and health infra, and the

UTTAR PRADESH

THE YOUNG TURKS

They may be a vanishing breed in Indian politics in terms of sheer numerical strength, and Uttar Pradesh may be ground zero for some of the big issues that have contributed to their marginalisation. Despite that larger existential crisis, the 2022 assembly poll seems set to make a new beginning for Muslim politics in the state. The older faces would voice 'Muslimness' in ways that didn't necessarily ensure the best crossover appeal–take an Imran Masood, who hit the headlines with intemperate remarks against Narendra Modi before the 2014 general election, or Yakub Qureshi, who announced a reward of Rs 51 crore for anyone beheading the Danish cartoonists who satirised the Prophet and justified the *Charlie Hebdo* attack. Neither has a ticket to ride this time. Instead, UP is seeing the arrival of a new set: young, educated, articulate.

"Parties opposing the BJP have refrained from fielding Muslim leaders embroiled in controversies in the past and made provocative statements. They feel it contributed to counter-polarisation," says Gyas Asad Khan, retired principal of Azamgarh's



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



THE MILLENNIAL MUSLIM FACE
Clockwise from top left: Abdullah Azam Khan, Haider Ali Khan, Iqra Hasan (campaigning for brother Nahid) and Syed Asif Mian